



Alien Guitar Secrets

LESSON 4.1: UNLOCKING THE MAJOR SCALE

INTRODUCTION: THE MAJOR SCALE – THE KEY TO UNDERSTANDING MUSIC THEORY

The major scale is considered the most fundamental building block in Western music theory. It serves as the foundation for countless melodies, harmonies, and chord progressions across all genres. For guitarists, understanding and mastering the major scale unlocks the fretboard and provides a solid framework for creating music, improvising, and building chords.

In this lesson, we'll explore the structure of the major scale, learn how to play it across the entire fretboard, and see how it connects to chords, arpeggios, and other scales. By the end of this lesson, you'll be able to play the major scale in multiple positions and understand its relationship to the music you play and hear.

WHAT IS THE MAJOR SCALE?

The major scale is a seven-note scale characterized by a specific pattern of tones (two frets) and semitones (one fret) between its notes. It has a bright, happy sound and is used to create major chords, diatonic chord progressions, and melodies.

Major Scale Formula:

The interval pattern for a major scale is:

- **Tone, Tone, Semitone, Tone, Tone, Tone, Semitone**

This formula tells us the distance between each consecutive note in the scale. Let's break it down using the C major scale as an example:

C Major Scale Notes:

C - D - E - F - G - A - B - C (octave)

Interval Pattern:

Tone - Tone - Semitone - Tone - Tone - Tone - Semitone

- C to D: Tone
- D to E: Tone
- E to F: Semitone
- F to G: Tone
- G to A: Tone
- A to B: Tone



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- B to C: Semitone

This interval structure defines the sound of the major scale and remains consistent no matter where it's played on the fretboard or in any key.

LEARNING THE MAJOR SCALE ON GUITAR

To master the major scale on the guitar, it's essential to learn it in multiple positions and be able to connect these positions across the neck. Here's how you can approach learning and practicing the major scale.

1. Open Position Major Scale (Key of C Major)

Start by playing the C major scale in the open position. Use the following fret and string pattern:

C MAJOR SCALE - OPEN POSITION

T	A	B
0 1	0 2 3	0 2
1 0	2 0	3 2 0
		3

C Major Scale - Open Position

Practice Tip: Say the note names aloud (C, D, E, F, G, A, B, C) as you play. This helps reinforce note recognition.

2. LEARNING THE MAJOR SCALE IN FIVE POSITIONS (CAGED SYSTEM)

The CAGED system divides the major scale into five interlocking patterns that cover the entire fretboard. These patterns are named after the open chord shapes: C, A, G, E, and D.

- **Position 1: C Shape (C Major Scale Root on the A String, 3rd Fret)**
- **Position 2: A Shape (Root on the A String, 5th Fret)**
- **Position 3: G Shape (Root on the E String, 8th Fret)**
- **Position 4: E Shape (Root on the E String, 12th Fret)**
- **Position 5: D Shape (Root on the D String, 10th Fret)**

By learning these positions, you'll gain the ability to play the major scale all over the neck and connect the shapes smoothly.

Practice Tip: Focus on one position at a time. Once comfortable, try moving between adjacent positions.



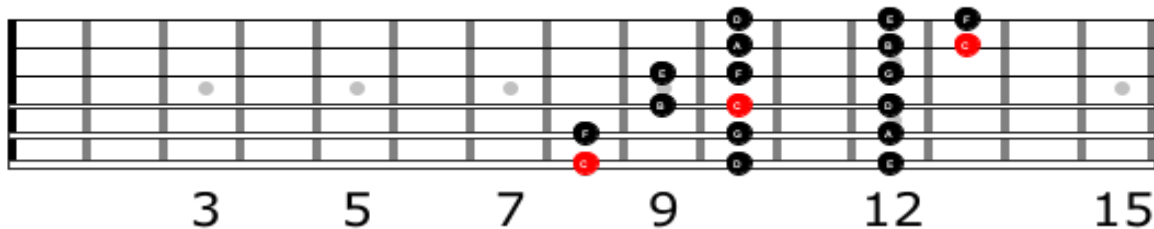
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3. LEARN THE MAJOR SCALE USING THE 3 NOTE PER STRING METHOD

The 3-Note-Per-String method is a powerful way to play scales on the guitar, offering a consistent and systematic approach to covering the entire fretboard. As the name suggests, this method involves playing three notes on each string, which allows for a more fluid, linear movement across the neck and enables faster scale runs due to its symmetrical nature. This approach also helps eliminate the "boxy" feel that traditional scale positions can sometimes create, providing a smoother, more connected visualization of the fretboard.

In the 3-Note-Per-String system, each scale shape extends horizontally across more frets compared to the CAGED system. This wider spacing helps guitarists develop better finger independence, as well as the ability to shift quickly between positions and play larger intervallic jumps. For example, the C major scale using the 3-Note-Per-String method would be played as: C-D-E on the 5th, 7th, and 9th frets of the low E string, F-G-A on the 5th, 7th, and 9th frets of the A string, and so on. This layout enables smoother transitions between notes, making it an ideal system for legato techniques, faster alternate picking, and complex melodic lines often used in rock, metal, and progressive guitar playing.

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4. Connecting the Scale Across the Fretboard Using Caged System

Play the major scale across the entire fretboard by starting in one position and shifting into the next. This helps you visualize the scale patterns as a continuous sequence rather than separate shapes.

Exercise: Play a C major scale starting from the 3rd fret (Position 1) and continue through Positions 2, 3, 4, and 5 until you reach the 12th fret (octave).

EXERCISES FOR UNLOCKING THE MAJOR SCALE

EXERCISE 1: PLAY THE MAJOR SCALE IN ONE OCTAVE

1. Choose a starting note on any string.
2. Play the major scale up and down one octave, saying each note aloud.
3. Repeat this process, starting from each finger: 1st, 2nd, 3rd, & 4th fingers respectively



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EXERCISE 2: PRACTICE THE MAJOR SCALE USING CAGED SYSTEM

1. Play the major scale using Position 1 (C shape).
2. Move to Position 2 (A shape) and continue up the neck.
3. Connect each position smoothly, visualizing the entire fretboard.

EXERCISE 3: PRACTICE THE MAJOR SCALE USING THE 3 NOTE PER STRING METHOD

1. Play the major scale starting from the lowest possible note on Fretboard ie. The Low E 6th String E Phrygian in a ascending form (See PDF Tabs)
2. Move to F Lydian and use a descending method, and continue up the neck
3. Practice Slow and intentionally, singing the notes as you play them

EXERCISE 4: BUILD CHORDS FROM THE MAJOR SCALE

1. Choose a root note (e.g., C).
2. Play a major triad using the 1st, 3rd, and 5th notes (C, E, G).
3. Play through all the diatonic inversions of the assigned triad in that key.